

Launching where learners live

Week 9, Lecture 1 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Community norms, channel fit, Show HN mechanics

What we'll cover

- Why community norms determine whether your post survives day one
- The comprehensible-input community as LangoBee's ideological home
- r/languagelearning and r/Spanish: reading the room before posting
- Show HN mechanics: what qualifies and how the queue works
- Channel fit: ranking venues by audience, norms, and prior tool reception
- This week's task: write the posts before you press submit

Community norms and give-before-ask

Why posts get removed before anyone reads them

Every language-learning community enforces rules that catch promotional posts at the gate:

- r/languagelearning (3.4M members): direct app-launch posts without established karma are removed
- r/Spanish (434K members): mentions LingQ and Duolingo constantly, but only when organically relevant
- r/dreamingspanish: Patreon + Reddit complement; moderators permit introductions after genuine participation
- r/SaaS: once-per-60-days self-promo cap; repeat violations blacklist the URL

The pattern: every community rewards value-first participation and punishes cold pitches.

(communities.json, April 2026 data)

Give-before-ask: the mechanics

The give-before-ask principle is not courtesy; it is the operating mechanism of community trust:

- Karma accumulates from helpful comments, not from promotional posts
- Moderators distinguish "member who builds tools" from "founder who drops links"
- A post from a 3-year member with 400 karma survives; the same post from a 0-karma account is removed on sight

Rachitsky's study of 40+ consumer apps found that community-oriented tactics require enlisting community members as advocates, not broadcasting at them. (Rachitsky, 2020)

First step before any launch post: participate in the community as a learner.

The comprehensible-input community as ideological home

Why ideology matters for channel fit

LangoBee is not a flashcard app. It is a comprehensible-input (CI) content player.

That distinction matters because CI learners already have a coherent worldview:

- Input before output
- Native content over manufactured lessons
- Engagement with real material, not spaced-repetition drills

Dreaming Spanish is the most-followed CI creator. The Refold network (14 servers, ~9,500 in the Spanish server alone) is the most sophisticated CI practitioner community.

These communities are predisposed to LangoBee's thesis. They are also the most likely to flag inauthenticity.

The Refold Espanol Discord: the right room

Refold Espanol is the highest-signal customer research community available to LangoBee:

- ~9,500 members, part of the 14-server Refold network
- Refold's immersion-first methodology matches LangoBee's product thesis exactly
- Members compare tools frequently: Anki, Language Reactor, LingQ, mpv scripts

Not a launch venue. A research and validation venue. Participate first. Understand the tool stack they currently use. Test whether LangoBee's native-content angle resonates before any product mention.

The ask phase comes after the research phase -- if at all.

Reddit mechanics: r/languagelearning and r/Spanish

Reddit: rules and the karma runway

r/languagelearning (3.4M members): self-promotion rules are strict; launch posts without karma are removed. Build karma by answering resource questions genuinely for weeks before any product mention.

r/Spanish (434K members): Dreaming Spanish is discussed organically here. Resource mentions survive when they are responses to existing threads, not standalone announcements.

Both communities reward specificity. "I watch CI Spanish videos for 30 minutes a day using LangoBee" in a comment is legitimate. "Check out my app" as a post is not.

The karma runway is 4-8 weeks of genuine participation. Alstromer: find where early adopters concentrate, then craft message-match copy. The concentration work comes before the copy work. (Alstromer, 2022)

Show HN mechanics

What qualifies for Show HN

Show HN is for interactive, runnable projects: not blog posts, not signup pages, not landing pages.

Qualifying submissions:

- The product must be live and tryable without an account (or with a frictionless signup)
- The title format: "Show HN: [product name] -- [one-sentence description]"
- Submissions appear first on the shownew page before earning enough upvotes to reach the main show page

What the YC team says: "Please only submit projects that you have made yourself. Submissions should be interactive and something people can try." (Y Combinator, 2012)

LangoBee qualifies: it is live, it is interactive, and a visitor can read a text and tap words without creating an account.

Show HN norms that determine reception

Three behaviors that improve Show HN reception:

1. **Frictionless tryout.** The first comment must contain a link the visitor can follow without signing up. Demo mode, sample content, or a read-only view.
2. **Honest top comment.** What you built, why you built it, what stage you're at. Not marketing copy.
3. **Engaged responses.** The founder replies to every comment, including hostile ones. HN values intellectual engagement.

Three behaviors that kill Show HN posts before they reach the main page:

- Asking for upvotes
- Deleting or ignoring critical comments
- Submitting while the product is behind a paywall with no trial

HN audience vs Reddit audience

Show HN reaches a technically sophisticated but skeptical audience. For LangoBee:

- Technical credibility helps: the word-level status tracking, the per-video difficulty score, the comprehension RPC are interesting to HN
- The "YC-adjacent" distribution is real: a well-received Show HN generates press mentions and creator outreach
- HN is not the comprehensible-input community; expect fewer learners and more engineers

The channel is complementary, not redundant. HN can send early technical users who become power users and write about the product. Reddit sends the actual learners.

(Manalac, 2019: distinct audience-message pair per launch phase)

Most founders treat a launch as a one-time high-stakes event. The best founders treat it as a repeatable experiment they run again and again with different audiences. (Paraphrased)

Kat Manalac, Y Combinator (2019)

How to Launch (Again and Again)

Channel fit: ranking the four venues

- r/dreamingspanish: CI ideology match, small but high-signal
- Show HN: technical audience, tryout-first norms, founder-credible
- r/languagelearning: largest audience, strictest self-promo rules
- r/Spanish: mid-size, Dreaming Spanish fans present, but karma required

Higher fit (launch now with retention gate)

Lower fit (requires karma runway first)

Manalac's multi-phase framework: soft launch (Discord), community launch (HN + r/dreamingspanish), broader community (r/languagelearning + r/Spanish) only after retention validates the funnel. (Manalac, 2019)

Take-aways

1. Community norms are not suggestions; they determine whether your post stays up. Read the rules of every venue before writing a word.
2. The comprehensible-input community is LangoBee's ideological home. Participate there as a learner first; any product mention follows genuine membership.
3. Show HN qualifies LangoBee because it is live and tryable. The top comment must offer frictionless access and honest context.
4. Channel fit has three variables: audience overlap, platform norms, and prior tool-launch reception. Rank venues on all three before choosing the order.
5. Give-before-ask is the operating mechanism of community trust. Karma is not optional; it is the prerequisite.

What's next

- **Reading:** "Week 9: Community launch and channel fit" at </c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk09>
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** The launch as an instrument -- UTM discipline, message match, burn risk
- **Section this week:** Draft the Reddit post and Show HN post; pre-mortem the top ten hostile comments
- **HW4 "The launch and the creator wave" goes OUT this week**